

The Dangers Of Ultra-Processed Foods

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Secondo diversi studi, gli alimenti ultraprocesati dovrebbero essere regolamentati allo stesso modo del tabacco: sono dannosi per la salute e anche progettati per favorire i loro effetti di dipendenza.



Ultra-processed foods (UPFs) have more in common with cigarettes than with fruit or vegetables, and require [far tighter regulation](#), according to a new report. UPFs and cigarettes are engineered to encourage addiction and consumption, researchers from three US universities said, pointing to the parallels in widespread health [harms](#) that link both. UPFs, which are widely available worldwide, are food products that have been industrially manufactured, often using [emulsifiers](#) or artificial colouring and flavours. The category includes [soft drinks](#) and packaged snacks such as crisps and biscuits. There are similarities in the production processes of UPFs and cigarettes, and in manufacturers' efforts to optimise the doses of products and how quickly they act on [reward pathways](#) in the body, according to the paper from researchers at Harvard, the University of Michigan and Duke University. They [draw on](#) data from the fields of addiction science, nutrition, and public health history to make their comparisons, published on 3 February in the healthcare journal the Milbank Quarterly. The authors suggest that marketing claims on the products, such as being “low fat” or “sugar-free”, are “healthwashing” that can [stall](#) regulation, [akin to](#) the advertising of cigarette filters in the 1950s as protective innovations that “in practice offered little meaningful benefit.” “Many UPFs share more characteristics with cigarettes than with minimally-processed fruits or vegetables and therefore [warrant](#) regulation [commensurate with](#) the significant public health [risks they pose](#),” they concluded. One of the authors, Prof. Ashley Gearhardt of the University of Michigan, a clinical psychologist specialising in addiction, said her patients made the same links: “They would say, ‘I feel addicted to this stuff, I [crave](#) it — I used to smoke cigarettes [and] now I have the same habit but it’s with [soda](#) and doughnuts. I know it’s killing me; I want to quit, but I can’t.’” The debate around UPFs [fits](#) a [well-worn pattern](#) in the field of addiction, according to Gearhardt. She said: “We just [blame](#) it on the individual for a while and say ‘Oh, you know, just smoke in moderation, drink in moderation’ — and eventually we get to a point where we understand the [levers](#) that the industry can pull to create products that can really hook people.” While food, unlike tobacco, is essential for survival, the authors argue that the distinction makes action doubly necessary because it is difficult to opt out of the modern food environment. Current Affairs

Growing Underground: Food For The Future Sotto le strade di Londra, è nato un nuovo tipo di agricoltura. Coltivazioni sostenibili e tecnologia all'avanguardia si uniscono per offrire una soluzione innovativa per nutrire le città del futuro. Daniel Francis, Julian Earwaker Gearhardt said it should be possible to distinguish between harmful UPFs and other [foodstuffs](#) in the same way that alcoholic drinks are differentiated from other beverages. UPFs meet “established [benchmarks](#)” as to whether a substance should be considered addictive, the paper argues, with design features that “can drive compulsive use” — although “the [harms](#) of UPFs are clear, [irrespective of](#) their addictive nature”. The authors suggested that lessons from tobacco regulation, “including litigation, marketing restrictions and structural interventions”, could offer a guide to reducing harm

related to UPFs, calling for public health efforts to “shift from individual responsibility to food industry [accountability](#).” Ultra-processed food contains higher levels of salt, sugar, fat and additives that are associated with obesity, cancer, type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular disease. Prof. Martin Warren, chief scientific officer at the Quadram Institute, a specialist food research centre, said that while there were parallels between UPFs and tobacco, the authors risked “[overreach](#)” in their comparisons. There were questions, he said, over whether UPFs were, like nicotine, “intrinsically addictive in a pharmacological sense, or whether they mainly exploit learned preferences, reward conditioning and convenience”. He said it was also important to consider whether the adverse health effects attributed to UPFs came from their contents, or because they replaced “whole foods rich in fibre, micronutrients and protective phytochemicals”. He said: “This distinction matters, because it influences whether regulatory responses should mirror tobacco control or instead prioritise dietary quality, reformulation standards, and food system diversification.” Dr. Githinji Gitahi, chief executive of [Amref](#) Health Africa, said: “This journal article reinforces a growing public health alarm sounding across Africa [where] corporates have found a comfortable, and profitable, nexus: weak government regulation on harmful products and a changing [pattern](#) of consumption. “All this places new and preventable pressures on already [stretched](#) health systems,” he said. “Without publicly-led interventions on the rising [burden](#) of [non-communicable diseases](#), we risk health systems’ collapse.”

WHAT IS ULTRA-PROCESSED FOOD?

Ultra-processed food involves extremely high levels of manufacturing to produce. It includes all [formula milk](#), many commercially-produced baby and [toddler](#) foods, [fizzy drinks](#) and sweets, fast food, snacks, biscuits and cakes, as well as mass-produced bread and breakfast cereals, [ready meals](#) and desserts. Ultra-processed ingredients include fruit juice concentrates, maltodextrin, dextrose, golden syrup, hydrogenated oils, soya protein isolate, gluten, “mechanically-separated meat”, organic dried egg whites, as well as rice and [potato starch](#) and corn fibre. Additives such as monosodium glutamate, colourings, [thickeners](#) and [glazing agents](#) are also ultra-processed. Ultra-processed food contains higher levels of salt, sugar, fat and additives that are associated with obesity, cancer, type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular disease. They also tend to have lower levels of protein, zinc, magnesium, vitamins A, C, D, E, B12 and niacin necessary for a child’s optimal growth and development. It is also thought that other mechanisms are at play in UPFs being associated with worse health [outcomes](#), including negative effects on the development of [gut microbiota](#). Published in The Guardian on 3 February 2026. Reprinted with permission.

Glossary

- **benchmarks** = parametri di riferimento
- **warrant** = richiedere, meritare
- **fits** = corrispondere
- **well-worn** = trito e ritrito
- **irrespective of** = indipendentemente da
- **accountability** = responsabilità
- **stretched** = sovraccarico
- **non-communicable diseases** = malattie non trasmissibili
- **formula milk** = latte artificiale
- **far tighter regulation** = regolamentazione molto più rigorosa
- **harms** = danni
- **soft drinks** = bibite
- **crave** = avere voglia di, desiderare
- **soda** = bibite
- **ready meals** = piatti pronti
- **potato starch** = fecola di patate
- **thickeners** = addensanti
- **emulsifiers** = emulsionanti
- **reward pathways** = sistemi di ricompensa
- **pattern** = schema
- **overreach** = eccesso, forzatura
- **burden** = fardello
- **glazing agents** = agenti di rivestimento
- **outcomes** = esiti
- **draw on** = basarsi su
- **risks they pose** = comportare rischi
- **levers** = leve
- **stall** = ostacolare, frenare
- **blame** = incolpare
- **toddler** = bambino piccolo (da uno a tre anni)
- **gut microbiota** = microbiota intestinale
- **akin to** = simile a
- **Amref** = African Medical and Research Foundation (ONG)
- **fizzy drinks** = bibite gassate
- **commensurate with** = adeguata a, proporzionata a
- **foodstuffs** = prodotti alimentari